Knowledge explosion

There is so much more information and inspiration online now via things like Google Images, Instagram, Facebook, Pinterest, YouTube, web newsletters from suppliers and woodturners' own websites. The world of woodturning is much more accessible these days.

The important aspect of woodturning today is that professionals are prepared to give their knowledge to help other turners, either via teaching individuals in smaller classes or giving group demonstrations at symposiums or club meetings. Audio-visual monitors and microphones mean that groups can see and hear clearly what is happening at the lathe. The demonstrators need good sketches with computer-generated drawings, with models of tools, to help the audience understand grinds and shapes of chisels.

- If the demonstrator is a good turner, this does not always mean he can teach it. If you understand the demonstrator then he is doing a good job. He should have the ability to keep you involved throughout the session. Demonstrations are generally much better today than they were in the 1990s.
- Make sure to check about the demonstrator or person who is going to teach you before you commit.
- Chapters and clubs also promote turning and are becoming more professional about presenting topics. Still today very few woodturners are making a living from just turning and selling items. We see turners who have many 'strings to their bow', for example turning and selling functional items and turning to request. Some conduct classes; make DVDs on aspects of turning, sharpening or finishing; write articles for magazines on projects; or offer advice on types of lathes to purchase.

In Australia, turners demonstrate at individual woodturning clubs and also at 'Working with Wood' shows throughout the country. 'Turnaround Down Under' is held annually in Phillip Island, Victoria; with up to 110 attending, 45 turners will bring along a lathe and share their knowledge, there are no structured demonstrations. Each person will do their own thing, and experienced turners will help out the beginners without being bossy. The more you give the more you will receive while sharing information. Maybe you can help with sharpening advice and explain how to present the tool to make a particular cut on the wood safely, and give confidence to the participant. Being a woodturner in your own shop can be quite lonely and gathering together is great. 'Turnaround Down Under' is a live-in weekend, fully catered for, from Friday until Sunday. These weekends are organised by volunteers and any money raised via raffles and silent auction goes to a local charity, Country Hope, and other recognised charities. There are numerous other weekend events held in Australia, including Forest Edge Victoria, Wagga Turnabout NSW and Saturn SA. 'TurnFest' is Australia's premier woodturning event. Held annually in Queensland, it presents world-class demonstrators with 350 plus participants, this means Aussie woodturners are kept informed of the latest development in tools and techniques.

'Container Series' in sheoak. Finished with superglue, U-Beaut Shellawax Glow and Traditional Wax. 122 x 115 x 63mm

'In the family' in sassafras. Bark to bark, top of bowl heart of tree, turned wet (green) and surface dried with a propane torch, sanded and coated with one coat of Rustin's Oil, then put in the freezer for about 24 hours, removed and thawed out, then placed in the refrigerator where excess moisture was drawn out of the wood. Resanded and a final finish applied. 592 x 547 x 180mm

Carving on turned pieces

Back in the 1980s and 90s there were no rotary carving tools available, most carving was done with hand tools, surforms and coping saws. Now with the progress in technology and suppliers becoming aware of the need for some form of powered tools, woodturners can adapt and use power appliances; hence the job is completed much quicker. Power mini carvers for removing excess timber, rotary tools – die grinder – with appropriate burrs, Dremel and ArborTech tools and accessories have made woodcarving much more advanced. Skill and safety precaution is needed when using these tools, as well as earmuffs, glasses/face shields and respirators or masks. Magazines and DVDs offer further inspiration and information about decorative techniques.

Chucks and attachments

When I started turning we used blocks of wood as carriers, which could be either glued or screwed to the base of a bowl. Even a faceplate screwed to a block of wood was used to carry the main piece of the wood. Today turners have the advantage of a variety of four-jaw expanding and contracting systems, a very good quality of chucks and the use of variable speed systems for large and smaller lathes. For the hobbyist you do not need all the chucks and attachments, you can use wood fitted to your jaws, which gives you a variety of options, depending on your needs and direction.

Vacuum chucks are now widely available. There are also plate kits that have a vacuum pump with a chucking system to suit a number of different shapes, and a vacuum plate that fits onto the spindle head of the lathe, which can be controlled by a household vacuum cleaner. This was developed in Australia by Woodfast Machinery and Vicmarc Machinery in the late 90s and is now available worldwide using either system.

Hollowing systems

Hollowing systems are now available that use laser technology to measure the thickness of walls and ball bearing supports to suit

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